A Lost Land Under the Sea

From: Popular Mechanics Mined: 2026-11-13 3 min read

Imagine a land almost as big as North America, hidden under the sea. Jerome E. Dobson, a **geographer**, calls it **Aquaterra**, a name he first used in 1999. In a 2014 paper, he said this land of about 22.5 million square kilometers may have been home to the first human groups.

During ice ages, water froze into ice, and sea levels fell. Low land now under water became dry, with **grasslands**, **wetlands**, and forests full of life. People lived there for most of 120,000 years, Dobson says.

When the ice melted, the seas rose and covered these places. Jericho was a town when seas were about 50 meters lower than today. But older things, like early **pottery**, may lie deeper.

New finds back up the idea. In 2021, researchers Michael K. Faught and Morgan F. Smith wrote about seven projects in North America. In the Gulf of Mexico, they found burned wood, seeds, and bones up to 9,000 years old. In Belize, they found the outlines of Maya salt-making buildings and a stone object more than 12,000 years old.

Word Treasure

geographer -- A geographer is a person who studies the land and places on Earth.

Aquaterra -- Aquaterra is the name given to a huge lost land that is now under the sea.

grasslands -- Grasslands are wide open lands covered mostly with grass.

wetlands -- Wetlands are lands where the ground is often wet or covered with shallow water.

pottery -- Pottery is bowls, pots, and other objects made from baked clay.

Background you need

Aquaterra is a name for a huge area of land that is now hidden under the sea.

During ice ages, much of the world's water froze into ice, so sea levels fell and low land became dry land where people could live.

When the ice melted, the seas rose again and covered that land, hiding the places where early people once lived.

Break it down

WHO: Jerome E. Dobson, a geographer, and researchers Michael K. Faught and Morgan F. Smith

WHAT: Dobson says a vast land called Aquaterra, now covered by the sea, may have been home to the first human groups, and new underwater finds support the idea

WHERE: In low land now under the sea, including the Gulf of Mexico and Belize in North America

WHY: During ice ages, water froze into ice and sea levels fell, so the land became dry and people could live there; when the ice melted, the seas rose and covered it again

Why it matters

It shows that the first homes of people might be hidden under the ocean, so exploring the sea can help us learn where humans began.

Test what you remember

1. What name did Jerome E. Dobson give to the hidden land?

(A) Belize
(B) Aquaterra
(C) Jericho
(D) North America

2. About how large is Aquaterra, according to Dobson?

(A) About 22.5 million square kilometers
(B) About 50 square kilometers
(C) About 9,000 square kilometers
(D) About 120,000 square kilometers

3. Why did sea levels fall during the ice ages?

(A) The land sank into the sea
(B) People dug canals
(C) Water froze into ice
(D) The seas dried up in the sun

4. For how long does Dobson say people lived on this land?

(A) For 9,000 years
(B) For 50 years
(C) For most of 120,000 years
(D) For 12,000 years

5. How much lower than today were the seas when Jericho was a town?

(A) About 50 meters lower
(B) About 22.5 meters lower
(C) About 9,000 meters lower
(D) About 12 meters lower

6. What did researchers find in Belize?

(A) The outlines of Maya salt-making buildings and a stone object more than 12,000 years old
(B) Grasslands, wetlands, and forests
(C) Burned wood, seeds, and bones up to 9,000 years old
(D) Early pottery from Jericho

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Jerome E. Dobson: He says Aquaterra may have been home to the first human groups and that people lived there for most of 120,000 years.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):